USSR.[42] This bizarre assessment emanated from a GRU source in the Kennedy administration who reported that a decision to launch a US first strike had been taken in June 1961.

Gilpatric's speech, however, carried a clear warning to Moscow. If the US could strike harder in retaliation than the Soviets could in a first strike, then the United States could strike even harder in a first strike. Furthermore, if Washington knew the numbers of Soviet ICBMs, it suggested they knew where they were. And as a 1961 US National Intelligence Estimate noted, the Soviet ICBM complexes 'are highly vulnerable to attack.'[43]

In *Dr Strangelove*, when the Chief of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, General 'Buck' Turgidson (memorably played by George C. Scott), argues for a pre-emptive attack on the Soviet Union President Merkin Muffley (memorably played by Peter Sellers) insists that 'it is an avowed policy of the United States that we will never strike first with nuclear weapons'. In Western culture, the idea that it is only 'the bad guy' who fires first is ingrained. Kennedy himself had affirmed that he would not initiate a nuclear war. However, US (and NATO) strategy was predicated on exactly that. And the Strategic Air Command saw firing first as essential to US national security. In October 1961 Kennedy had discussed with the Joint Chiefs how he might launch a first strike, should he choose (though he remained wholly sceptical about the idea).[44] Yet, in an interview with Stewart Alsop in the *Saturday Evening Post* in March 1962, Kennedy mused:

> Of course in some circumstances we must be prepared to use the nuclear weapon at the start, come what may – a clear attack on Western Europe, for example. But what is important is that if you use these weapons, you have to control their use. What you need is control, flexibility, a choice. [45]

The President further stated that 'Khrushchev must not be certain that where its vital interests are threatened, the United States will never strike first … In some circumstances, we might have to take the initiative.'

Stuffing hedgehogs down trousers